

See also: The Domesday Book 58–59 ■ The *Lex Mercatoria* 74–77 ■ The Peace of Westphalia 94–95 ■ Vattel's *The Law of Nations* 108 ■ The Treaty of Versailles 192–193 ■ The Helsinki Treaty 242–243



Christopher Columbus lands in the West Indies on an island he named San Salvador. Believing they had reached east Asia, Columbus and his crew dubbed the locals “Indians.”

John II that he had discovered a New World on behalf of the king’s Spanish rivals was a bombshell.

John sent a threatening letter to King Ferdinand and Queen Isabella, claiming that under the 1479 Treaty of Alcáçovas and the 1481 papal bull (a sacred decree with the force of law), all lands south of the Canary Islands—and therefore all the lands discovered by Columbus—belonged to Portugal. John also announced that he would dispatch a fleet to make good the Portuguese claim.

The papal bull

Aware of Portugal’s naval might, Ferdinand and Isabella appealed to the Pope, Alexander VI, knowing they would get a sympathetic hearing since Alexander was a fellow Spaniard. He responded with what now seems like a breathtaking

statement of European self-belief, issuing a papal bull that divided the entire world, by this time known to be round, into two halves. The line ran from pole to pole, north to south through the Atlantic Ocean, 100 leagues (about 345 miles/550 km) west of the Azores and Cape Verde, and crossed through what is now the easternmost tip of Brazil. All land to the west of the line not already ruled by a Christian monarch would henceforth belong to Spain and everything to the east would belong to Portugal.

The Pope’s solution inflamed tensions, as each country sought to move the boundary line farther east or west. Finally, in 1494, diplomats from Spain and Portugal met in the Spanish town of Tordesillas and came up with a deal: the Treaty of Tordesillas. This upheld the division of the world in half, but Portuguese naval prowess meant the boundary was pushed west by 270 leagues.

The treaty’s new line was drawn at approximately 46°30’W by modern calculations. At that time,

no one had any way of calculating longitude accurately, so it was inevitable that there would be disputes. And while dividing the world in half north–south down the Atlantic, it did not specify whether the line continued around the world to divide the Pacific as well.

South America divided

Despite its huge shortcomings, the treaty proved surprisingly effective. It left Portugal in control of the route around Africa to India until it was supplanted later by the British. It also gave Portugal control of Brazil, when 6 years later Pedro Álvares Cabral landed there while sailing south through the Atlantic en route to India. Some historians maintain that, at the time of Tordesillas, the Portuguese already knew of this huge eastward bulge of South America and kept quiet about it. Whatever the truth, its legacy was to give Portugal the riches of Brazil, while Spain exerted its influence over the whole of the rest of South and Central America, dominating what is now called Latin America. ■

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This boundary ... shall be drawn ... at a distance of three hundred and seventy leagues west of the Cape Verde Islands.

Treaty of Tordesillas

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